

# FOR THE LOVE OF STAMPS

Dinesh Kanabar's enviable collection is not just about stamps, it's a slice of history

BY SMITA TRIPATHI



**T**he very first stamp of independent India was an aeroplane, the second was a portrait of Gandhi that was printed in Switzerland but couldn't be used in India, because the gum of the stamp wouldn't stick in India's humid climate. Dinesh Kanabar, one of the country's leading international tax experts, is an encyclopaedia on Indian stamps with an enviable collection of pre-Independence stamps and archival material.

For the 63-year-old CEO of Dhruva Advisors, stamp collecting started in college as a hobby. "My father collected post-Independence stamps and I inherited his collection," says Kanabar. However, he then became a chartered accountant and everything else took a back seat. It was somewhere in the mid-1990s that he read an article in *The Economist* which said how the prices of Mongolian vases had increased significantly because China was prospering. The article also referred to how prices of stamps, coins and other Chinese artefacts had increased in price because everyone wanted a piece of Chinese history/heritage. "It was then that it struck me that I had a stamp collection that I had not looked at for over a decade and that I should see what was happening in the Indian stamp market." This was immediately post liberalisation and the Indian stamp market was pretty stagnant. Kanabar thought of buying a few stamps but in those days there weren't too many sellers in India. "There was a time when you couldn't get anything in India but now there are auctions in India as well," he says. It turned out to be fortuitous because he started bidding at global auctions. "I could remit money from India and have them delivered

**THE PHILATELY KING** Kanabar's collection focusses on pre-independent India